route that took them first into Afghanistan, on to Sinkiang and then into Han China, or through the regular maritime trade routes that linked South India with Southeast Asia and the southern Chinese ports. All the regions along the route through which the travelling monks transited were also at the time influenced by Buddhism.

Interaction between India and China was frequent during the Tang Period (ad 618-907) and then again during the Song Dynasty (ad 960-1279). Historical records in both countries indicate that the contact between the countries was a two-way street, with Chinese scholars also travelling to India to study and collect Buddhist documents for translation. The most famous visit was the sixteen-year pilgrimage of Hsüan-tsang who entered the subcontinent in ad 630. After his return, he spent the remaining years of his life in the Temple of Great Happiness translating his Indian collection, assisted by twenty monks who were well versed in both Chinese and Sanskrit. During this period, the Chinese scholar-monk recorded in minute detail his travels in India while also translating important Chinese books into Sanskrit that were then sent to Nalanda in ad 647.

Other Chinese chronicles that were written between the sixth and sixteenth centuries meticulously record the visit of every Indian scholar who visited China during that period. Significantly, there is no mention of Padmasambhava or any of the others who visited Tibet and greatly influenced Buddhism there in Chinese texts—a strong indication that through this large span of Chinese history, Tibet was not considered a part of China and, in fact, had little to do with it.

TIBET'S RELATIONSHIP WITH CHINA

Even before 1949 when the Chinese effectively swallowed up Tibet, China had been behaving as if it 'owned' Tibet. But the facts, when looked at closely, tell a different story.

Despite the visits of scholars like Hsüan-tsang in the seventh century, the two civilizations did not have much to do with each other. Even the Opium Wars towards the end of the nineteenth century did not bring the two races face to face. India's interaction was with the Tibetan people. Administratively, it was restricted to exchanges between the British and the Tibetan government once the Sikhs were defeated in the northwest, the Gorkhas in the centre, and the Burmese in the east by the East India Company. As the British Empire expanded, it overpowered Burma, Bhutan,